almost meant as a rhetorical answer to the Centre, whose Ujjwala scheme has faced criticism for the fact that prohibitive LPG costs make subsequent refills impossible for targeted families. So Gehlot has decided to offer cylinders at just Rs 500 per unit to 7.6 million families. In a move that will mitigate rural distress on another front, the state will pay Rs 40,000 as compensation for each cow that perished to lumpy cow disease, besides an insurance cover of Rs 40,000 to cover two milch cows—this is estimated to benefit close to two million farmers. Gehlot's budget also lightens the burden on the state's hefty road tax and vehicle registration costs, providing Rs 2,500 relief for a 100cc scooter, Rs 8,000 for an 800cc car and up to Rs 20,000 for a diesel vehicle.

The minimum social security pension has been doubled to a thousand. Gehlot will also roll out Rahul Gandhi's 2019 election promise of a minimum guaranteed income scheme, most likely by merging various state employment guarantees and related schemes to introduce a comprehensive social security-linked monthly income. Amid BJP criticism that his schemes will remain on paper, he said he was setting an example for the Centre to implement all over the country. "The Centre gives us Rs 300 crore, but we spend Rs 9,000 crore on pension to the needy. Each state does it as per its capacity. Let the Centre bring a law to have a uniform level of assistance," Gehlot says.

Late on the night of February 13, Gehlot issued transfer orders for 75 IPS officers; a similar IAS reshuffle is also expected soon. Perhaps the penultimate reshuffle of top officers, with another expected closer to elections, it seems a last-ditch effort to improve governance while also accommodating the recommendations of the party leaders. How much will all of this help Gehlot? It's anybody's guess. "I do my best," is all the chief minister says. That's better than what his party sometimes does. ■

–Rohit Parihar



ANI

KERALA

BITTER MEDICINE

There were few surprises when Kerala finance minister K.N. Balagopal tabled the 2023-24 state budget in the assembly on February 3. Prices of liquor were up, again, as were land registration charges, and there was a new social security cess of Rs 2 per litre on petroleum products, which makes even going to the gas station an onerous task of nation-building for citizens. As expected, the opposition was soon out on the streets against the "anti-people budget".

But the abstract economics is perhaps scarier. Kerala has been wrestling with budget deficits and mounting public debt for over two decades now. Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan of the CPI(M) has defended the new taxes on the grounds that hard decisions were needed after the Centre limited the state's borrowing limit "without considering our financial structure". Besides, almost perversely, Kerala is paying for having a declining population with a per capita income that's been rising. Using those indices as parameters, the state's share of the divisible pool of central taxes was trimmed down to 1.92 per cent in 2020-21—less than half of the